THE VENERABLE

MAHANT RAJGIRI JI

'AMBASSADOR BABA' ROLLS IN

His four-wheeled chariot is no less than a moving shrine, outfitted with bells, cymbals, and statues of Shani, Shiva, Ganesh and Parvati riding as passengers. A speaker mic, a radio and a mosquito net complete the accessories. A devotee, cured of a severe skin condition that defied modern medicine, gifted him the Amby some 35 years ago—it gives the Mahant his popular *nom de sanctus* on social media, and always arrives at the Kumbh before the rest of the saints come marching in. Given away at infancy by his parents to a guru at Juna Akhara, he was raised in the austere ways of asceticism—at 14 or so, he took the vows of a Naga sanyasi. When not in his hut in Indore, his ashram-on wheels carries him across India. He never lets anyone else drive it, and prioritises its repair before all else. "Devotees come and go, but it has never betrayed me ," he smiles. "Sometimes, it even starts on its own!"

